
The Global Burden of Mental Illness:

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap (World; 2023)

PROJECT CODE

DATE

Public Health Policy Brief 2026-04-21

 **KEY INSIGHT** Lifetime risk of major depression is substantial



Women

1 in 3

will experience major depression in their lifetime



Men

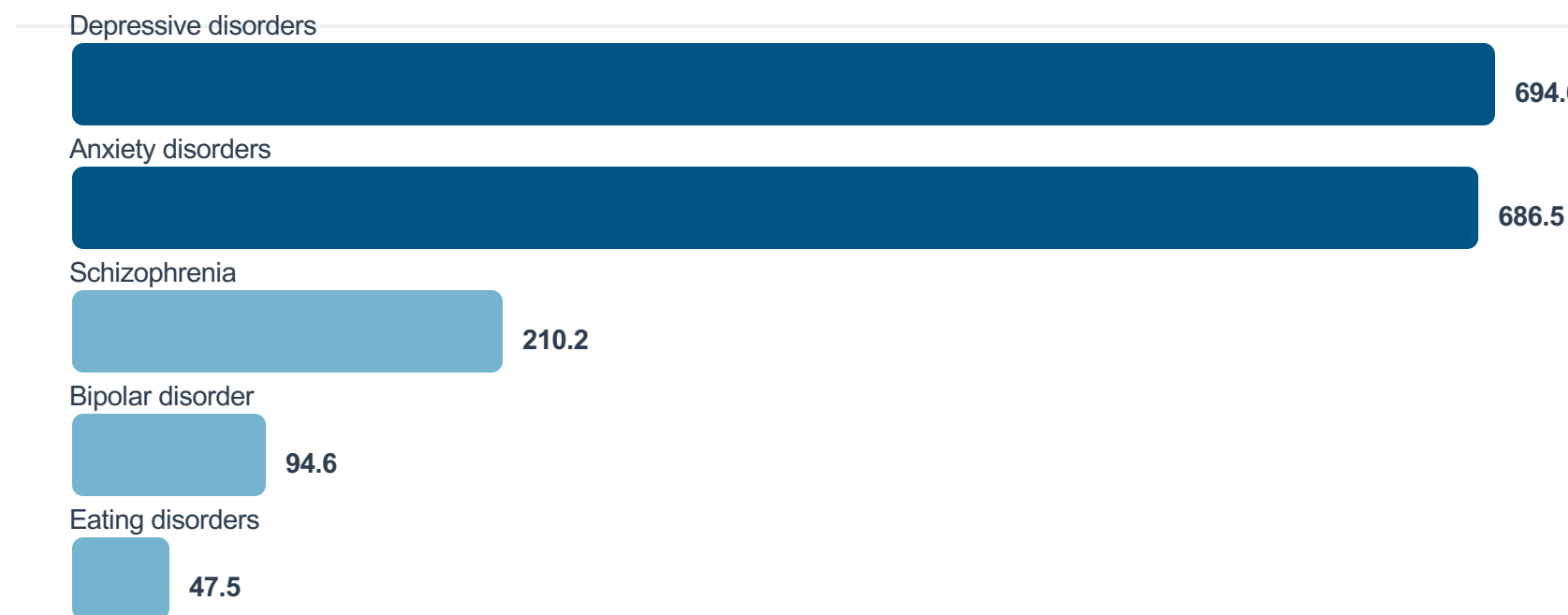
1 in 5

will experience major depression in their lifetime

Mental health conditions range from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar). Poor mental health affects well-being, ability to work, and relationships.

KEY INSIGHT Depression and anxiety dwarf other categories in DALYs

DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Interpretation

Depression and anxiety dominate global burden (~695 and ~687 DALYs)

Other categories are substantially smaller

KEY INSIGHT Depression and anxiety carry nearly equal disease burden

DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)

Depressive disorders

694.6

Anxiety disorders

686.5

Near-parity worldwide

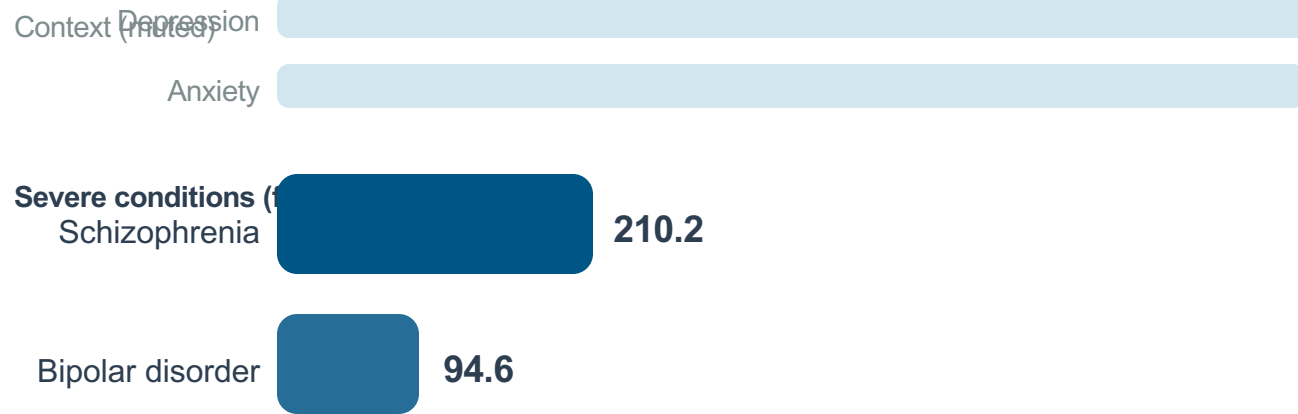
Depression and anxiety have nearly identical DALY rates.

~690 DALYs per 100K each

Across these five categories, they dominate overall burden.

KEY INSIGHT Lower population DALYs, but severe disability

DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Policy implication

Population-level DALYs are lower than depression/anxiety, but disability is severe.

Maintain specialized care while scaling services for common disorders.

 **KEY INSIGHT** Treatable conditions, yet access and quality fall short



Treatments exist

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced.



Access is lacking

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality can be poor

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



Stigma and underreporting

Discomfort sharing symptoms makes true prevalence hard to estimate; burden may be

 **KEY INSIGHT** Coping strategies vary; responses are shaped by context

Global surveys: common coping strategies for anxiety or depression



Prescribed medication

Common in higher-income settings



Religious / spiritual

Prevalent in many regions



Talk to family / friends

Widely reported coping mechanism

Responses vary widely across countries; policy should be culturally sensitive.

THANK YOU

Policy priorities

- Depression and anxiety are dominant and near-equal contributors to mental health DALYs.
- Schizophrenia and bipolar have lower population DALYs but severe disability.
- Treatment exists, yet access and quality are often inadequate.
- Stigma contributes to underreporting and suppresses help-seeking.
- Scale interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.